DOCUMENT-BASED QUESTION

# 3.3 Lincoln's Vision

Politicians and public officials use speeches to express their views on public policy. During his political career, Abraham Lincoln delivered a number of speeches, several of which became some of the most formative speeches in U.S. history.

For nearly 100 years, historians believed that no photos existed of Lincoln delivering the Gettysburg Address. But in 1952, National Archives employee Josephine Cobb was examining a crowd shot taken by photographer Mathew Brady at Gettysburg on November 19, 1863. She had the photo enlarged and examined where she thought Lincoln might have been standing in that crowd. And right there, in the middle of the crowd, she identified the out-of-focus—but unmistakable image—of Abraham Lincoln delivering the Gettysburg Address. You can see this rare photo below.

Lincoln was not known as a speaker gifted with a captivating voice or dramatic delivery. Rather, the force of his speeches came from the words themselves. For example, the Gettysburg Address is just 272 words long, and it took only around three minutes for Lincoln to deliver it. But in this succinct address, Lincoln reminded Americans of the foundation on which the United States was built and on which it still rested. Quite intentionally, he framed his words around the principles of liberty and equality as set forth in the Declaration of Independence.

**CRITICAL VIEWING** Locate Abraham Lincoln in the photograph below. What do you notice about Lincoln's position in the crowd and how it differs from the ways in which the president is protected in public today?





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## DOCUMENT ONE

**Primary Source: Speech**
**The Gettysburg Address, by Abraham Lincoln, November 19, 1863**

As president, Lincoln used the opportunity of a battle site dedication to appeal to his fellow citizens to take up "unfinished work" of those who had died. He begins by situating his words in time by using the phrase "fourscore and seven" as a way of expressing the number 87. The word *score* means 20, so *fourscore* equals 80. By referring to 87 years ago, Lincoln asks his listeners to remember the American Revolution and the nation's founding principles of liberty and equality.

**CONSTRUCTED RESPONSES**

What did Lincoln mean by "testing whether that nation or any nation so conceived and so dedicated can long endure"?

What action did Lincoln propose as the best way to honor those who had died at Gettysburg?

Fourscore and seven years ago our fathers brought forth on this continent a new nation, conceived in liberty and dedicated to the proposition that all men are created equal.

Now we are engaged in a great civil war, testing whether that nation or any nation so conceived and so dedicated can long endure. We are met on a great battlefield of that war. We have come to dedicate a portion of that field as a final resting-place for those who here gave their lives that that nation might live. It is altogether fitting and proper that we should do this.

But in a larger sense, we cannot dedicate, we cannot consecrate, we cannot hallow this ground. The brave men, living and dead who struggled here have consecrated it far above our poor power to add or detract. The world will little note nor long remember what we say here, but it can never forget what they did here.

It is for us the living rather to be dedicated here to the unfinished work which they who fought here have thus far so nobly advanced. It is rather for us to be here dedicated to the great task remaining before us—that from these honored dead we take increased devotion to that cause for which they gave the last full measure of devotion—that we here highly resolve that these dead shall not have died in vain, that this nation under God shall have a new birth of freedom, and that government of the people, by the people, for the people shall not perish from the earth.

## DOCUMENT TWO

**Primary Source: Speech**
**from Second Inaugural Address, by Abraham Lincoln, March 4, 1865**

When Lincoln delivered this speech in March 1865, the North was close to victory. Lincoln did not speak of happiness, nor did he gloat about the South's impending defeat. Instead, he spoke about his sadness over the loss of life during the war. Just over a month later, the president who had saved the Union would be assassinated.

**CONSTRUCTED RESPONSE** What was Lincoln referring to when he called on Americans "to bind up the nation's wounds"?

With malice toward none, with charity for all, with firmness in the right as God gives us to see the right, let us strive on to finish the work we are in, to bind up the nation's wounds, to care for him who shall have borne the battle and for his widow and his orphan, to do all which may achieve and cherish a just and lasting peace among ourselves and with all nations.

## SYNTHESIZE & WRITE

1. **REVIEW** Review what you have learned about the events leading up to Lincoln's address at Gettysburg and his Second Inaugural Address.
2. **RECALL** On your own paper, write the main themes that emerge from the Gettysburg Address and this excerpt from Lincoln's Second Inaugural Address.
3. **CONSTRUCT** Construct a topic sentence that answers this question: What was President Lincoln's vision for the United States after the Civil War, and how did he try to persuade Americans to support that vision?
4. **WRITE** Using evidence from this chapter and the documents, write a persuasive paragraph that supports your topic sentence in Step 3.



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